

CELEBRATING EXCELLENCE Seated 5th from left onwards, Goa Chief Minister Dr Pramod Sawant, Union Minister of Tourism and Culture Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, India Today Group Chairman and Editor-in-Chief Aroon Purie, Goa Minister of Tourism Rohan Khaunte; standing 11th from right, Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa, with representatives of the winning states at the India Today Tourism Survey & Awards 2026 in Goa

Currently, India hosts 20 million international travellers annually, and the tourism sector's contribution to GDP stands at 6 per cent. The long-term goal, envisioned by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, is to cater to 100 million tourists annually and raise the GDP share to 10 per cent by 2047. When that goal is met, tourism will become the country's second-largest employment generator after agriculture, noted Shekhawat, who also presented the India Today Tourism Awards to representatives of 23 states across 11 categories in the presence of Goa chief minister Dr Pramod Sawant.

In his inaugural keynote address as chief guest, Pusapati Ashok Gajapathi Raju, Governor of Goa, noted that the state has in recent years transformed from a destination known primarily for its beaches into one defined by experiences. "People are no longer looking merely for places to visit. They are looking for experiences that are authentic, meaningful and memorable. They seek culture, nature, wellness, learning and adventure. And Goa is uniquely positioned to offer all of these."

INDIA TODAY TOURISM AWARDS WERE PRESENTED TO 23 STATES ACROSS 11 CATEGORIES

The summit saw states such as Goa and Rajasthan express their intent to move beyond their stereotypical images. In a fireside chat, Rohan Khaunte, Goa's minister of tourism, said the state was looking beyond its beaches to showcase its verdant villages, temples, churches, sports and vibrant culture to domestic and international tourists. Shuchi Tyagi, secretary, department of tourism, arts and culture, Rajasthan, revealed that the state was diversifying beyond the perception of being a land of forts and palaces. It is promoting wildlife, desert safaris, astro, religious and rural tourism.

States are also keen to break the mould, transitioning from simply encouraging visits to creating immersive experiences. While Maharashtra seeks to highlight its hidden gems—from ancient geoglyphs to beaches, forts and World Heritage Sites—Madhya Pradesh is working towards achieving a synergy between tourism and wildlife, while neighbouring Chhattisgarh is promoting a unique tourism model centred on tribal and non-tribal festivals.

The pages ahead capture the key insights, strategies and success stories redefining tourism in India. ■